

BRIDGING THE GAP
The team of YourDost, a mental health support platform

more into community living and meaningful offline relationships—you were never alone because there was a household to guide you," says Dr Sameer Malhotra, head of the department of mental health at Max Hospitals, Saket, Delhi, and a member of several city school managing committees. "There was also a lot of physical movement that channelised youthful energy into something constructive. No social media to disrupt lifestyles, so one could quickly move on from small emotional challenges. Now, the young sort of stay stuck in them." Over the past few years, he points out, his hospital has noticed a rise in psycho-emotional problems among youth, coupled with a reduction in coping mechanisms. Looking for quick solutions, the inability to understand the superficiality of online life, anger attacks, career and academic anxiety, substance abuse, and even existential crises where teens feel they've done it all and see no point in living, are a few of the recurring themes he encounters. "The young today have such heightened expectations of themselves that unmet needs are leading to frustration and intolerance," he says.



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DR SAMEER MALHOTRA
Head, Department of Mental Health, Max Hospitals, Saket, Delhi

The young themselves are not entirely untouched by stigma either. In 2021, Live Love Laugh, a mental health support foundation launched by actor Deepika Padukone in 2015, conducted a study titled 'How India Perceives Mental Health' involving 3,497 people in the 18-45 years age group across nine Indian cities. Though the study showed considerable improvement in terms of the number of people who thought that individuals with mental illness can eventually excel in their career and personal lives (from 32 per cent in 2018 to 65 per cent in 2021), 10 per cent of respondents still said they would not befriend a person with mental illness. The share of people who said they would limit their interaction with such a person or even urge others to avoid them was 9 per cent each.

Even if an individual does ultimately decide to battle such judgement and stigma and seek help, obstacles abound: there is either too little awareness, or help is simply unaffordable. Hitesh Sanwal, now 30, experienced anxiety and depression when he was 19. During the course of his treatment, he realised how strong the stigma and lack of awareness around mental health were. "I came from an educated and privileged background and even then I didn't know much about mental health till I experienced related issues," says Sanwal. That led him to start Youth for Mental Health (YMH) in 2019, a platform to advocate and advance mental health awareness through various campaigns and initiatives. Since its inception, YMH has organised over 30 initiatives and is